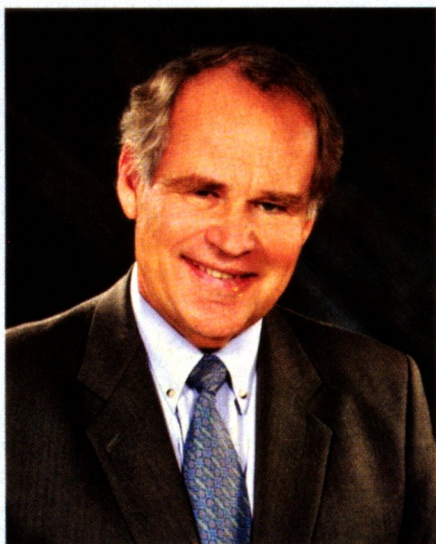




H E Ole Lønsmann Poulsen
Ambassador of Denmark

In the past 10 to 15 years, with the emergence of globalisation, commercial relations between India and Denmark have flourished. Denmark currently ranks as the 19th largest investor in India, ahead of countries such as Russia and Norway. Around 75 Danish companies operate in India. Politically, the ties between India and Denmark have never been stronger. Indo-Danish relations have today developed into a multi-faceted partnership, encompassing high-level political dialogue, trade investments and cultural exchanges.

I believe that there is scope for expanding Indo-Danish co-operation even more in the future. In 2007, the Danish Government presented a strategy for Danish Foreign Policy in a globalised world. The strategy has a clear emphasis on Asia (and on India in particular, in acknowledgement of the country's growing economic and political weight).

As a direct result of the strategy, the Danish Government has taken a number of steps to enhance Denmark's presence in and knowledge about India. In 2007, the Danish Parliament adopted an Action Plan for the Global Marketing of Denmark, which includes several initiatives specifically targeted on trade opportunities with India. An additional export and investment promotion advisor has already been recruited at the Royal Danish Embassy, and we plan to open an additional trade office in India by 2009.

In October 2007, Danish Foreign Minister Per Stig Møller carried out a successful visit to India. In February 2008, Danish Prime Minister Anders Fogh Rasmussen will make his first official visit to the country.

Realising the many possible avenues of further commercial co-operation between Denmark and India, I am pleased that the Prime Minister will be accompanied on his trip by a Danish business delegation. The delegation is focussed on — biotech; and information and communication technology — two of India's main growth sectors. I am convinced that the visit will spurn increased business co-operation.

Denmark is one of the world's most highly developed countries in terms of information and communication technology, consistently ranked at the very top of international surveys on e-readiness, etc. India, on its part, has a vast resource pool of highly qualified personnel for furthering developments in this sector. Information and communication technologies could become one of the major areas for Indo-Danish co-operation.

The same applies for biotech and life sciences, in general, where the extensive research and development efforts carried out by firms in both countries could

prove to be of mutual benefit. Denmark is in the top of the Best Performance Index of Biotechnology Innovation Scoreboard of the European Commission and has one of the highest commercial drug development pipelines in Europe, in absolute numbers. Combined with the world-class research facilities in India, the potential gains for both the countries could be considerable.

An important outcome of Prime Minister Fogh Rasmussen's visit will be the establishment of a Joint Commission between India and Denmark, an initiative which has been underway for several years, and which Rasmussen is to finalise during his meeting with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. The Joint Commission will establish a new platform for an expanded partnership between India and Denmark, both in the commercial and political area.

The common political agenda of India and Denmark will be further explored in the Prime Minister's bilateral meetings with, among others, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and President of the Congress Party, Sonia Gandhi. Denmark and India have a shared interest in forging a strategic partnership that will enable us to pursue solutions to global problems such as climate change and international terrorism. Similarly, Denmark recognises that India is poised to play an increasing role on the world stage through its impressive economic growth. The Prime Minister will, I am sure, use the opportunity to reiterate Danish support for a reform of the UN, reflecting the world of today. This includes enlargement of the Security Council, where Denmark supports a seat for India.

Prime Minister Rasmussen's stay in Delhi also coincides with the Delhi Sustainable Development Summit. Denmark considers climate change as one of the biggest global challenges of our time and has therefore accepted to host the UN Climate Conference in Copenhagen in 2009 (COP15) where we hope to reach agreement on a new climate deal.

We believe that economic growth can indeed be achieved without drastic increases in the emissions of greenhouse gases, which is the generally accepted cause of climate change. And, the Danish experience proves it. Danes use about the same amount of energy today as they did in 1980. But in the same period, the Danish economy has grown by approximately 70 per cent. The key tools are energy efficiency and the use of renewable energy resources.

As India's energy-starved economy demands new sources of energy, the sustainable energy sector is yet another obvious avenue for further Indo-Danish co-operation. Thirty years of absorbed energy policy have catapulted Denmark ahead of most other nations in the use of renewable energy technology and resulted in renewable energy sources accounting for more than 15 per cent of today's total energy consumption in Denmark.

One of the energy sectors where Denmark leads the way is the wind energy industry, where Denmark plays a central role on the world market. However, Denmark also has strong research activities in technologies such as hydrogen and fuel cells. Hence, not least in energy efficiency and CO₂-reducing technologies for industries and utilities, Danish technology providers are in a position to offer strong co-operation to Indian companies and governmental institutions. Danish competence in this field can efficiently be applied to the Clean Development Mechanism (CDM) projects in India, thereby ensuring technology transfer whilst reducing CO₂ emissions.

In conclusion, there is no doubt that for Denmark, India is an extremely important partner, both political and commercial. India is the world's largest democracy and a growing political and economic power. As one of the world's oldest democracies, Denmark will continue to be an active and constructive partner for India. We share values of pluralism and human rights, and we stand together in promoting the interests of developing countries.

I believe that the co-operation between Denmark and India holds enormous potential — now and in the future. And, I am convinced that the Danish Prime Minister's visit will be the starting point for deepening of our already close relations.